Learner Workbook

Applied AI and Automation for Executives. One page for each session. Write in it, or type in Word.

How to use this workbook

Each page has the day's question, your steps for your own company task, the fields to fill in, two questions to think about and one decision.

The practice files and templates named on a page are in your Templates and Practice Files folders. The answers to class exercises are not in this workbook.

Your task from Session 1 follows you through every page. Write about the same task each time.

My task (fill in after Session 1)

My task	
Owner	
How often and how long it takes today	
What better means (a number)	
Tool I use for AI work	

Session 0, the introduction

AI and machine learning: the map before the route

What do I need to understand about AI before I decide anything about it?

Your steps for today

- Read the Course Handbook before Session 1. Optional.
- Write down the three recurring tasks you will bring to Session 1.
- Write any question from today that was not answered.

Fill in

Three recurring tasks I may bring to Session 1	
One idea from today I could explain to a colleague	
A question from today that I still have	
My AI assistant and Google account are ready (yes or no)	

Think about

Which field or industry use on today's slides is closest to my company?

_____

Which role in the line from data to decision is missing in my company?

_____

My decision

The three tasks I will bring.	

I keep: The Course Handbook, with today's ideas, a glossary and what to prepare. Read it before Session 1.

Session 1

Where AI fits in your business

Which tasks in my company should AI touch first?

Your steps for today

- List ten recurring tasks and mark the kind of work each one is: rules, patterns, drafting or judgement.
- Score five of them for value, risk and checkability, and place them on the picture.
- Choose one task. Write its task card with a baseline, and mark every number E (estimate) or M (measured).

Fill in

Task I chose	
Owner	
How often	
Time it takes today (minutes each time, and how many people) and E or M	
Volume: how many a month, and E or M	
Hours a month today (how often x minutes / 60) and E or M	
Usual errors and what each costs, and E or M	
What better means (a number I can check)	
Why I chose it	
Optional: one moment this week when the task went wrong	

Think about

Which task did I almost choose, and why did I not?

_____

What would make me stop and not use AI for this task?

_____

My decision

My chosen task and the reason.	

I keep: Your completed use-case scorecard and one-page task card. This task stays with you for the whole course.

Session 2

How AI works and where it fails

When can I trust what an AI tool tells me?

Your steps for today

- Write my chosen task, and where AI text would enter it.
- Mark which of the four failures could hurt it: made-up facts, beyond the document, sources that disagree, wrong sums. Name the one that would hurt most.
- Write one check for each failure I marked, who does it and how many minutes it takes. Compare the total with the review time on my task card.
- Write what I will rely on the tool for, what I must always check and what I will not use it for.

Fill in

My task and where AI text would enter it	
The failure that would hurt most, with an example	
Check 1: failure, check, owner, minutes	
Check 2: failure, check, owner, minutes	
Check 3: failure, check, owner, minutes	
Total minutes of checking, against the review time on my task card	
I can rely on the tool for	
I must always check	
I will not use it for	

Think about

Which of the four results surprised me, and why?

_____

Which number do I pass on today without recounting it?

_____

My decision

How far I rely on an AI tool for my task, and the main check that goes with it.	

I keep: Your reliability page for your own task, and the four controls from today.

Session 3

Working with AI tools

How do I brief an AI tool and check what it returns?

Your steps for today

- Answer the five account questions for the assistant I could use: does it train on what I paste, how long does it keep chats, who in my company can see them, is it a work or personal account, does my company rule allow it?
- Write all seven parts of the brief for my own task. Part 5 holds the shape of a good answer, with a short invented example. Part 7 says what to write when unsure.
- Write my check plan: the figures, names and dates the answer will carry, what I compare each with, who does it and the minutes.
- Compare the check minutes with the review time on my task card.

Fill in

Assistant and account type	
My answers to the five account questions	
My brief: parts 1 to 7	
My check plan: item, compare with, who, minutes	
Total check minutes against my task card	
The part of the brief that was hardest, and why	
What I will do next: save, ask a colleague to read it, or revise after Session 4	

Think about

Which part of the weak email would have worried me most if I had sent it?

_____

Which rule from my Session 2 page belongs in my brief?

_____

My decision

Save, ask a colleague to read it, or revise, with the reason.	

I keep: Your seven-part brief for your own task, in the Reusable Brief Template, and your plan for checking the result.

Session 4

Your information: is your data ready for AI?

Is my company's data ready for AI, and what must I fix first?

Your steps for today

- Open the Information Inventory. List at least four sources my task uses, with owner, format, where it lives and who may see it. Label each by sensitivity and add + Personal when it names a living person.
- Rate the six areas Green, Amber or Red using the rule table. Write one line of evidence for each. Add the points: Green 2, Amber 1, Red 0.
- Choose my top three data gaps. For each, write the evidence, one first fix and a possible owner.

Fill in

Sources listed (number)	
Sources labelled Confidential or + Personal (number)	
Inventory: rating and evidence	
Readable: rating and evidence	
Complete and unique: rating and evidence	
Metadata: rating and evidence	
Rights: rating and evidence	
Current: rating and evidence	
Total out of 12	
Gap 1: evidence, first fix, possible owner	
Gap 2: evidence, first fix, possible owner	
Gap 3: evidence, first fix, possible owner	
Optional: the answer to the question I asked a source owner	

Think about

Which rating surprised me, and what evidence changed my mind?

_____

Which source would I most like to use with AI, and which gap stands in the way?

_____

My decision

The gap I will fix first, and why.	

I keep: Your Information Inventory, your scored readiness scorecard and your top three data gaps. Session 12 turns them into a roadmap.

Session 5

Reviewing documents with AI

How can AI help me review documents without missing what matters?

Your steps for today

- Choose one kind of document you review in your company and write five to ten numbered rules for it.
- Write the request you would give an AI assistant: the document, the rules, the table with exact quotes, and NOT FOUND allowed.
- Write the check plan: who searches every quote, who decides, what you remove first, and where you record who decided.

Fill in

Document I chose	
My rules (numbered, one line each)	
What I remove before sharing	
The table columns I ask for	
Who searches every quote	
Who decides, and who they escalate to	
The level of checking I chose and why	
Where I record who decided	

Think about

Which of my rules could I not state clearly, and who can?

_____

Which decision would I never give to an AI, and why?

_____

My decision

My level of checking for this document and the reason.	

I keep: Your review rules for one kind of document, the check plan with named people, and the Document Review Table to use with them.

Session 6

Automation 1: a rule-based workflow

What can a workflow of plain rules do for my messages, and where does it stop?

Your steps for today

- Name one recurring task in your company where a word rule could route the work. Write the rule in one sentence.
- Name one case where that rule would be wrong, and say what the wrong route would cost.
- Fill in the five controls for the task: owner, off switch, log, exception person and test.

Fill in

My task	
The rule in one sentence	
The words it looks for	
A case it would get wrong	
What a wrong route costs	
Owner	
Off switch: where it is and who may use it	
What the log records	
Who reads the exceptions	
The known cases I would test first, and where the key is	

Think about

Which part of my task depends on meaning, and which on fixed words?

_____

What would I want a vendor to show me before I trust a rule router?

_____

My decision

Rule is enough, rules plus a person, needs AI, or stays with a person, and why.	

I keep: Your workbook page: one task of yours that a rule could route, its rule in one sentence, and the five controls with names filled in.

Session 7

Agents and controlled actions

What may an automation do on its own, and what needs me?

Your steps for today

- Choose one automation or agent you might use, and fill the boundary table: what it may read, write, send and spend, what a person approves, and what it must never do.
- Name the owner, the log, two stop conditions and the off switch, with who turns it off and how fast.
- Replay the hidden instruction from the supplier email against your table and tighten one limit.

Fill in

The automation or agent	
It MAY read (name the label, folder or sheet)	
It MAY write	
It MAY send	
It MAY spend (a monthly limit)	
A person must approve	
It must NEVER	
Owner (a named person)	
What the log records	
Two stop conditions	
Off switch: who, where, how fast	
Level of freedom I chose and why	

Think about

Which tool in my company could send or forward my files today, and who approves it?

_____

Who could switch an automation off within minutes, and do they know?

_____

My decision

My level of freedom for this automation and the reason.	

I keep: Your boundary table and your Tool Boundary Sheet for one automation, with a named owner, a log and an off switch.

Session 8

Automation 2: an AI workflow

What does AI add to the same workflow, and what must a person still do?

Your steps for today

- Answer the five questions for your own task: who approves, which cases go straight to a person, what a wrong result costs, how you will measure, and what you would paste in.
- Split your task into steps and choose for each: rules, AI drafts and a person approves, a person only, or not yet.
- Write the first line of your policy: what is automated and what a person always does.

Fill in

My task	
Who approves each result	
Cases that go straight to a person	
What a wrong result costs	
How I will measure time and errors	
What I would paste in, and whether it is safe	
Step 1 and my choice	
Step 2 and my choice	
Step 3 and my choice	
The first line of my policy	

Think about

Which of the six approver questions would matter most for my task?

_____

What would I need to see before I trust an AI draft without reading it?

_____

My decision

For each step of my task: rules, AI drafts and a person approves, a person only, or not yet.	

I keep: Your workbook page: the five questions answered for your own task, and your decision on what you would automate and what stays with a person.

Session 9

Your AI use policy

What may my staff do with AI, and what rules should my company set?

Your steps for today

- Edit the Risk Register for your own task: a score, an owner and a control for every row.
- Write sections 3 and 4 of the AI Use Policy: approved tools and the data table.
- Write sections 5, 7, 8 and 10: review, owner, incidents and the review date.

Fill in

My task	
My top three risks, their scores and levels	
Owner and control for each	
Approved tools in my policy, each with an owner	
What may go in at each data class	
What always needs a named reviewer	
What we keep on record	
Who hears about an incident, and how fast	
What my lawyer must check	
Policy owner, deputy and review date	

Think about

Which risk surprised me when I scored it?

_____

Who in my company already uses AI through a personal account?

_____

What must my lawyer confirm before I write the breach reporting step into the policy?

_____

My decision

The owner and deputy of my policy, and the review date.	

I keep: Your Risk Register for the own task and the first draft of your company AI use policy, written from the template.

Session 10

Buying and oversight

How do I question a vendor, and how do I keep control of what I buy?

Your steps for today

- Pick one tool and answer the Vendor Question List for it from what you know today.
- Write five questions for the vendor, each with its red-flag answer.
- Fill in an oversight card: data location, terms, exit, audit and owner. Then choose build, buy or partner.

Fill in

The tool I chose	
My three biggest gaps	
My five vendor questions	
The red-flag answer for each	
Evidence I would accept	
Data location and training setting I need	
Caps, notice and deletion date I would ask for	
What I will review, and how often	
Owner and deputy	
Route chosen (build, buy, partner), the reason and the first step	

Think about

Which claim in a proposal would I have believed before today?

_____

Which question would my vendor least like to answer?

_____

Who must approve a purchase in my company?

_____

My decision

Build, buy or partner for my own task, with the reason and the first step.	

I keep: Your five vendor questions, your oversight card for one tool, and a build, buy or partner choice for your own task.

Session 11

The business case

Is it worth doing, and what would change my mind?

Your steps for today

- Type your Task Card numbers into Inputs and list every cost on Costs.
- Check Benefits, choose a haircut on Result, and set low, base and high on Sensitivity.
- Write three stop rules as numbers, then fill the one-page Sponsor Briefing.

Fill in

Task	
Times a month	
Minutes each time today	
Minutes with the tool, and review minutes (mark plan numbers E)	
Loaded hourly cost of staff time (pay plus employer contributions and benefits, over hours worked)	
Share of runs with an error, and cost of one error	
One-off cost and monthly cost (for a buy or partner route: the vendor's first-year total)	
Monthly net and payback (months)	
Haircut, risk-adjusted 12-month net and break-even haircut	
Low, base and high 12-month net	
Three stop rules	
My sponsor	
Go to a pilot, revise or stop, and the number that decided it	

Think about

Which input am I least sure of, and how would I measure it?

_____

Where in my company would a formula do the exact work, so that a person only judges what it flags?

_____

What would I tell staff the saved time is for?

_____

My decision

Go to a pilot, revise or stop, with the number that decided it.	

I keep: Your costed Business Case Workbook and a one-page Sponsor Briefing, with your go to a pilot, revise or stop decision and the number that decided it.

Session 12

Your data roadmap and 90-day plan

What will I fix first, who will own it, and how will I know it worked?

Your steps for today

- Turn my top three gaps from Session 4 into roadmap lines in the 90-Day Roadmap. Give each action one owner and one due date.
- Add the hours (marked E), what each action waits for, and a success measure that is a number. Write my first test: 20 questions with known answers and a pass line.
- Set my start date and the day 30, 60 and 90 check-ins, list three risks (one about people), share the roadmap with a partner and write down the feedback.

Fill in

My start date and the day 30, 60 and 90 dates	
Gap 1, action, owner, due date, hours (E), waits for, success measure	
Gap 2, action, owner, due date, hours (E), waits for, success measure	
Gap 3, action, owner, due date, hours (E), waits for, success measure	
My first test: the 20 questions, the traps and the pass line	
The test I will apply at day 30, day 60 and day 90	
Three risks to the plan, one about people, and who covers	
My sponsor	
Feedback from my partner: one thing clear, one question, one risk	
My action in the first 24 hours, its owner and its date	
My Session 4 total and my day 90 target	
One thing I will stop doing and one thing I will start	

Think about

Which feedback line will change my roadmap?

_____

Who will cover for the owner of my first action if the owner is away?

_____

What would make me stop and not test with AI at all?

_____

My decision

My action in the first 24 hours, its owner and its date.	

I keep: Your data roadmap and the follow-up kit (Check-in Form, Results Tracker, Sponsor Briefing), with the dates filled in.

Words used in this course

Word	What it means	First used
Model	The thing that has learned patterns and makes the predictions.	Session 0
Parameter	One of the many settings inside a model that training adjusts. Also called a weight.	Session 0
Training	Showing the model many examples and adjusting its settings until its errors shrink.	Session 0
Inference	Using a trained model to make a prediction or write an answer.	Session 0
Overfitting	When a model memorises its examples and fails on new ones.	Session 0
Task	One piece of repeated work with a clear start and finish, such as the weekly sales email.	Session 1
Use case	A task plus the tool you would use and the result you expect.	Session 1
Baseline	How the task performs today: time, volume, errors and cost. It is the number you must beat.	Session 1
Checkable	A result you can confirm quickly against a source, so a mistake is caught before it matters.	Session 1
Language model	The system inside an AI assistant. It writes text by predicting a likely next word from patterns it learned.	Session 2
Hallucination	A fluent answer that is false, such as an invented fact or an invented source.	Session 2
Context window	Everything the assistant can see at one time: your messages, your files and its own earlier replies.	Session 2
Control	A check you put in place so that a known failure is caught before it matters.	Session 2
Prompt	Anything you type into an assistant.	Session 3
Brief	A prompt written once, in seven parts, and reused.	Session 3
Assistant	The product you talk to. The model is the engine inside it.	Session 3
Source	The original document or sheet a figure or claim comes from.	Session 3
Inventory	A list of every source of information your task uses, with its owner, format, place and who may see it.	Session 4
Metadata	Facts about a file: its date, owner, version and subject. Without them nobody can tell which file is current.	Session 4
Personal data	Information about a person who can be identified, such as a name with a phone number. Your lawyer checks the Act's wording. Add "+ Personal" to its level.	Session 4
Scorecard	Six areas rated Green, Amber or Red: inventory, readable, complete and unique, metadata, rights, current.	Session 4
Playbook	Your own rules for one kind of document, written as short numbered checks.	Session 5
Source quote	The exact words in the document that support an issue. You can find them with the search function.	Session 5
Flag	An issue the review raises. A flag without a quote is a draft to check.	Session 5
Over-flagging	Raising an issue for text that already meets your rule.	Session 5
Automation	A set of steps that runs by itself when something happens, with no person starting each run.	Session 6

Word	What it means	First used
Trigger	The event that starts an automation, such as a new row of messages in a sheet.	Session 6
Rule	A fixed test on the data, for example: the text contains the word late.	Session 6
Route	Sending the message to a queue, which is the list one team works from.	Session 6
Log	A record of each run: what came in, which rule fired and where it went.	Session 6
Agent	An AI model given a goal and some tools, which chooses its own steps.	Session 7
Least privilege	Giving a tool the smallest permission that lets it do its job.	Session 7
Prompt injection	Text inside an email or file that tries to give orders to the AI reading it.	Session 7
Off switch	A named person and a way to stop the automation within minutes.	Session 7
AI workflow	An automation where an AI step reads the message and writes a draft, and a person approves it.	Session 8
Draft	A reply written by the AI that nobody has sent yet.	Session 8
Approval step	The point where a person reads a draft and chooses to send, edit or reject it.	Session 8
UNSURE	The answer we asked the AI to give when it cannot tell, so that a person decides.	Session 8
AI use policy	A short written rule for what staff may and may not do with AI tools at work.	Session 9
Data class	A level of sensitivity for information: public, internal or confidential, with a flag for personal data.	Session 9
Over-reliance	Trusting results because they are usually right, and checking less and less.	Session 9
Build, buy, partner	Make it with your own people, licence a product, or pay a firm to build and support it.	Session 10
Red flag	A claim, a term or a silence in a proposal that is a reason to question the vendor or to stop.	Session 10
Pilot	A small, time-limited trial on your own data, with a baseline, a success measure and a stop rule.	Session 10
Exit clause	The contract words that say how you leave, get your data back and have it deleted.	Session 10
Sub-processor	Another company that handles your data on the vendor's behalf.	Session 10
Payback	The number of months the monthly net takes to repay the one-off cost.	Session 11
Loaded hourly cost	Pay plus employer contributions and benefits, divided by hours worked. It is what an hour of staff time costs the company.	Session 11
Haircut	The share of the benefit you choose not to count, because estimates are rarely exact.	Session 11
Sensitivity	Trying a low, base and high version of your numbers to see whether the answer changes.	Session 11
Stop rule	A number written in advance that tells you to stop or revise.	Session 11
Roadmap	Dated actions, each with one owner and one measure, in the order they must happen.	Session 12
Owner	The one person who answers for an action.	Session 12
Dependency	An action that must finish before another can start.	Session 12
Success measure	A number someone else can check, such as 0 faults on a recheck.	Session 12

Word	What it means	First used
Check-in	A short report at day 30, 60 and 90, on the Check-in Form.	Session 12